



The heat of battle

Armed with M16 rifles, an M60 machine gun, and a sniper rifle—but without shirts, flak jackets, or helmets, because of the oppressive heat—members of the Ninth Infantry Division fight enemy forces in Cambodia's forest terrain.

Costs versus benefits

The attack lasted throughout May and June. It was the largest military sweep since Operation Junction City in 1967. The incursion was intended to force communist units away from Vietnam's border, thus buying time for Vietnamization and reducing pressure on Lon Nol's pro-American but precarious regime. US commanders claimed the operation killed around 11,000 enemy troops, destroyed 8,000 bunkers, found thousands of weapons and tens of thousands of rounds of ammunition, and seized tons of rice and medical supplies. The costs to the US and ARVN were also considerable, including 388 Americans and 638 South Vietnamese killed and more than 1,500 Americans and 4,000 ARVN soldiers wounded.

This costly effort did not have a significant impact on the strength of communist forces in Vietnam or move Le Duc Tho from his hardline position in the Paris peace talks. Moreover, the incursion failed to locate the COSVN. Instead of the jungle headquarters that the Pentagon had envisioned, there was what one journalist described as "a scattering of a few empty huts." The COSVN was not a place but a leadership group that moved frequently between various meeting sites in order to avoid attack or capture.

At a time when Washington was attempting to reduce the scale of its engagement in Indochina, the theater of war had expanded with the accompanying costs and risks.